

# The Confident Mind

Nathaniel Zinsser

## THE ARGUMENT

Where does the certainty you need at the moment of truth actually come from?

Not from what has happened to you. From how you have been thinking about what has happened to you. Confidence is not a trait, a mood, or a reward for a good week. It is a running total — the sum of every thought you have entertained about yourself and your work, changing with each new entry, and therefore something you deposit into or withdraw from every hour of every day. That is why a defensive end with ten sacks in ten games can believe he is terrible, and why a figure skater can fall through his warm-up and skate a gold-medal program twenty minutes later. Nothing that happens enters the account directly. A thought about it does, and the thought is yours to choose. The practical definition follows from this: confidence is a sense of certainty about your ability that lets you bypass conscious thought and execute unconsciously. Not a feeling added on top of the skill — the absence of everything that would get in the skill's way.

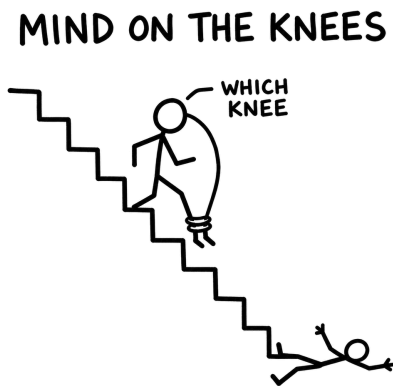
---

## THE MENTAL BANK ACCOUNT

One metaphor carries the whole book, and it is meant literally rather than poetically. A balance rises and falls by deposits and withdrawals; so does a sense of certainty. What follows is the account's full operation — what it sits on, the three sources you fund it from, how it is defended, and how it is spent. The order matters. You cannot open the vault on game day and find money you never put in.

- 1 **The four foundations** Four realities you stop arguing with before any of the rest works: your thoughts drive your physical state, you will never be perfect, your nervous system will fire up before anything that matters, and practice pays out late and unevenly.
- 2 **Deposits from the past** Your memory is a video library and you are the editor. The Top 10 list mines the whole career; the daily ESP entry banks one moment of effort, one success and one instance of progress; the immediate progress review carries the best rep of the last drill into the next one.
- 3 **Deposits in the present** Affirmations — statements about the reality you want, phrased as if it is already here. First person, present tense, positive, precise, powerful. Hung on a trigger you meet constantly, so the count runs into the thousands rather than the dozens.
- 4 **Deposits on the future** Envisioning: a controlled, multi-sensory, emotionally genuine rehearsal run from inside your own body. Detailed enough that the real arena feels like a return rather than an arrival.
- 5 **Anti-theft** Explain every setback as temporary, limited and non-representative. Get in the last word on your own negative self-talk — acknowledge it, stop it, replace it. Then go further with the shooter's mentality, where a miss makes the next hit feel more likely rather than less.

- 6     **Opening the vault** The pre-performance routine: take stock of what is actually in the account, take stock of the situation — the task, the hidden opponent, the room — and then decide that you have enough. Saver to spender. Workhorse to racehorse.
- 7     **Spending it, engagement by engagement** CBA before every rep, pitch, shift, patient or meeting. Cue your conviction with a short powerful phrase, breathe your body, attach your attention to the one thing that matters right now.
- 8     **The audit** The after action review, in three questions. What happened. So what does that tell you. Now what will you do. It ends by banking the highlights, which is what makes the next first victory cheaper than the last one.



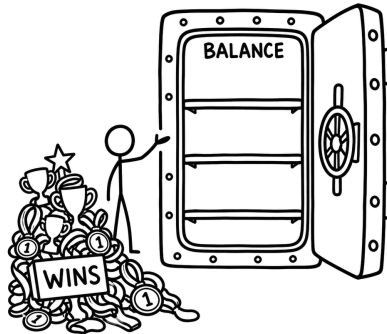
## Certainty is quiet

Confidence is not a loud belief laid over a skill. It is the absence of everything that would interfere with the skill. The working definition is a sense of certainty about your ability that allows you to bypass conscious thought and execute unconsciously — and the reason it has to be phrased that way is that human beings are wired to execute well-learned skills without watching themselves do it.

The psychologist Sian Beilock offers a demonstration anyone can run. If you were shuffling quickly down a flight of stairs and someone asked you to think about exactly what both your knees were doing, there is a good chance you would end up in a pile at the bottom. You already perform far more delicate things with total confidence. Ten fingers tie a shoelace through a sequence of tensions and releases and leave the right length of lace at the end, and no part of that reaches your conscious mind.

- Conscious, deliberate thought consumes a sizeable portion of the nervous system's capacity to take in what is happening, retrieve the right response, and send instructions back out to the hands, feet, throat and tongue. Every thought about how you are doing is taken out of the same budget as the doing. This is also why competence and confidence are different problems. The student who has learned all the material but doubts she has will not recall it cleanly, because the chatter blocks the retrieval.

## THE WINS NEVER GOT IN



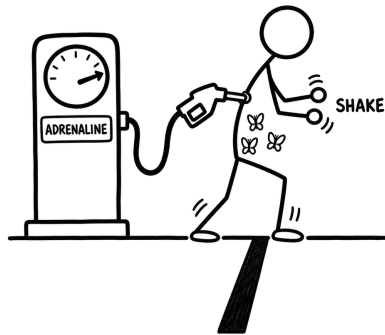
### Confidence is a running total, and nothing enters it by itself

It is tempting to think of confidence as a balance that events adjust for you — win and it goes up, lose and it goes down. It does not work that way. Nothing that happens to you enters the account. A thought about what happened enters the account. Success builds confidence only if you let it, and failure erodes it only if you let it.

In 1998 Michael Strahan recorded ten sacks in ten games, coming off an All-Pro season in which he led the league with fourteen. He told Sports Illustrated that he thought he sucked, that it was like we had no hope. Asked what being on the field looked like in his mind, he described chasing the quarterback, almost getting there, not getting there, and then everything goes black. Twenty years of highlights were sitting outside the account because the picture he replayed was of the near miss.

- The same asymmetry runs the other way, which is the encouraging half. Ilya Kulik's warm-up before the 1998 Olympic short program was a mess — slips, wobbles, no clean jumps. He skated near-perfect minutes later and won gold. Asked where the confidence came from, he shrugged: just from my mind. Two performers, opposite raw material, and in both cases the balance tracked what they chose to replay rather than what had actually occurred.

## THE JITTERS ARE THE FILL



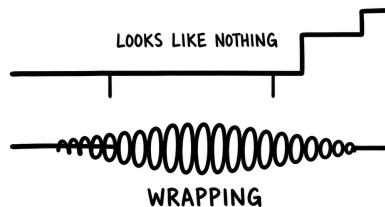
### The jitters are the delivery, not the warning

The racing heart, the sweating palms, the twitching hands and the stomach turning over are almost universally read as evidence that something is wrong. They are the opposite. They are the receipt for a delivery your body just made because it worked out that something important is about to happen.

Zinsser lays out the mechanism plainly. The unconscious part of the brain that registers an upcoming performance signals the adrenal glands, two small wads of tissue above the kidneys, whose one job is to release adrenaline into the bloodstream. The heart, receiving it, pumps harder and louder. Muscles primed by faster neural signalling twitch in anticipation. The hundred million neurons connecting brain to gut fire faster, and the smooth muscle in the stomach vibrates. Pupils widen. What you feel is the dose arriving, custom-made, correctly timed, and free.

- The misreading is learned, and learned early. Your first experiences of performance came before you had any skill, so arousal was reliably followed by disappointment and the two got wired together. It can be rewired. Michael Johnson, asked after the 1996 Games whether his heart was pounding in the blocks, said definitely, I was nervous — and when I'm nervous, I'm comfortable. Bill Belichick, forty-four years and six Super Bowls in, admitted he still gets nervous before every game. Expecting it is what makes it usable.

## THE FLAT IS THE FACTORY



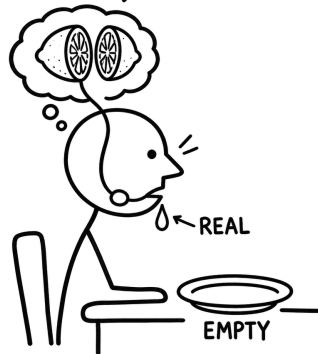
### The plateau is where the improvement is made

Practice does not pay out in a straight line. It pays out in long flat stretches interrupted by sudden bursts — and the longer you stay in a field, the longer the flats get and the smaller the bursts. This is the shape of every serious pursuit and almost nobody is told about it, which is why so many people conclude from a plateau that they do not have what it takes.

Neuroanatomy offers an account of where the work goes. Each nerve fibre is sheathed in myelin, a fatty insulation that behaves like the covering on household wiring; the more a circuit fires, the more myelin is laid down, and the faster and more precisely the signal travels through it. Zinsser cites a figure of up to a hundredfold increase in impulse speed once the sheath is thick enough. The catch is that laying it down is slow. The change is real, continuous and invisible.

- George Leonard put it in terms of learning systems: at the threshold there is an apparent spurt of learning, but this learning has been going on all along. The burst is not when you improve. It is when the accumulated improvement becomes visible. That reframes the flat stretch entirely — not something to be endured until progress resumes, but the place progress is manufactured. Everyone you are competing against is on the same schedule. Working with it slightly better than they do is the whole advantage.

## NO LEMON, SAME MOUTH



### A rep you imagine runs down the same wire as a rep you take

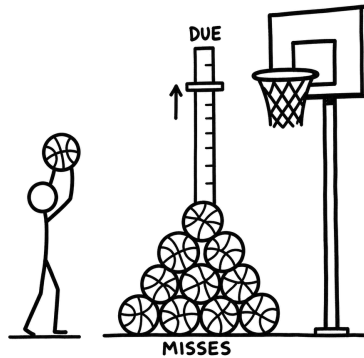
Vivid imagination is not a private slideshow with no consequences. It engages many of the same neural structures the real action engages, and the body responds accordingly — which means mental rehearsal is a way of getting reps that cost your joints nothing, and also that rehearsed failure carves its groove just as faithfully as rehearsed success.

Zinsser's demonstration is a lemon. Picture one on a plate, feel its waxy skin, cut it, lift a half to your face, bite into it. Your nostrils flare, the muscles around your mouth tighten, and you produce saliva — for a fruit that does not exist. In 1929 Edmund Jacobson recorded electrical activity in the thigh and calf of a sprinter lying still on a table imagining a hundred-metre dash; the extensors and flexors fired in the same alternating sequence as in running. A more recent study by Kai Miller's group at the University of Washington found imagined finger movements producing roughly a quarter of the motor cortex activity of real ones.

- Two things follow. Control is not optional — if an image of a mistake appears, you do what a director does and call cut, then reset the scene and run it to the ending you want. And perspective matters: rehearse from inside your own body, seeing what you would actually see, rather than watching yourself from the stands. Picture a rollercoaster from the car park and then from the front seat. Only one of those changes your heart rate.



### THE MISSES RAISE THE GAUGE



## A belief that helps you beats a belief that is accurate

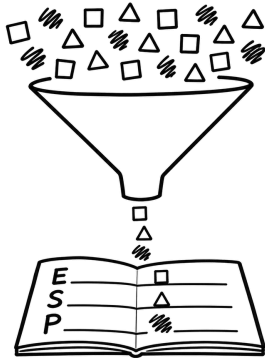
There is a moment in every performance where strict logic stops being useful. Logic says the best predictor of future behaviour is past behaviour, so the opponent who beat you will beat you again and the shot you have been missing will keep missing. Accuracy about what has already happened has no vote on what happens next, and treating it as though it does is often just negativity wearing a lab coat.

Bob Rotella once assembled a panel of Virginia's best athletes to describe their most confident moment. One of them, Stuart Anderson, told a story about a high school playoff game in which he had made one shot from fourteen. Score tied, final timeout, and the coach drew up the last play for somebody else. Anderson interrupted him: give me the ball, I want the shot, I'm due to get one in. He got the ball. He made it. The graduate students, all of them studying probability, asked how missing could improve his odds. After missing four or five in a row, he said, I figured my odds were way better than fifty percent. And on a hot streak? Then I think I'm going to make everything I look at.

- You have run this software before. At six years old you held a belief that you could ride a bicycle with no evidence for it and recent evidence against it, and that belief is the only reason you got back on. Zinsser calls it constructive delusion and treats it as a prerequisite rather than a flaw. Keep logic for the small hour-by-hour decisions and the single-skill drills. Throw it out for complex execution and for long horizons, where its only function is to talk you out of trying.

## ACTIONS

### THREE OUT OF EVERY DAY



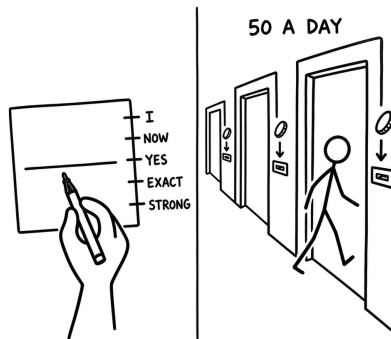
### Put the day through the filter and keep three things

At the end of each working day, take five minutes and a notebook. Write E and record one instance of honest effort — the drill where you dialed in, the stack of paper you finally sorted. Write S and record one thing you got right, however small. Write P and record one thing you got better at, even if you did not get it right. Three deposits, every day, whatever kind of day it was.

- Do the same thing at a smaller scale between activities and the count multiplies. Walking from one drill to the next, from one patient to the next, out of one class and toward another, take the single best rep of what you have just finished and carry it with you — a highlight with a very small h. A basketball player who does this arrives at the end of practice with a dozen already banked and a better practice behind them. Tony Gwynn ran the professional version: after every game he cut his at-bats into three video files, one for solid contact, one for good decisions, and a third for the bad ones, which he deleted.

Clients regularly say they could not find an E or an S or a P. The answer is that they are not looking carefully enough — go back through the day hour by hour and it is there. The deeper resistance is a belief that remembering your good moments is somehow improper or unrealistic. Consider what you are remembering instead.

## EVERY DOOR IS A DEPOSIT



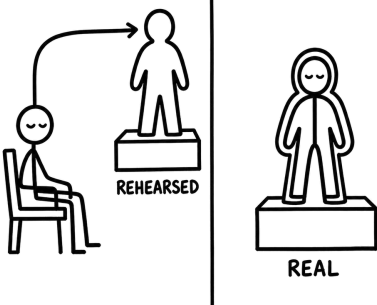
## Write the statement to five specifications, then hang it on a doorway

Compose three statements about the reality you want, phrased as though it is already here. Each one must be first person, present tense, positively worded, precise, and powerful. Then write three more: one for a quality you do not yet have, one for an action you do not yet take, one for an outcome you have not yet achieved. Then attach them to something you pass constantly.

- Alessandra Ross, a middle-distance runner whose personal best was two minutes and two seconds, repeated I run a one fifty-six eight hundred every time she walked through a doorway for nine months. At roughly fifty doorways a day that is thirteen thousand repetitions. Within a month she noticed the self-image starting to hold. She never ran the one fifty-six; she did set two consecutive personal bests at the Olympic trials, the only competitor in her event to do so. Dan Jansen used the other trigger — writing I love the thousand a dozen times a night for two years before finally winning his event in world record time.

Positive wording is not a stylistic preference. I never miss my second serve and my second serve lands just inside the line sound similar and are not: the part of the brain that runs the serve recognises the active verb missing and pulls up the memories that go with it, reinforcing exactly what you were trying to avoid. State what you want more of.

CUT THE SHAPE, THEN STEP IN



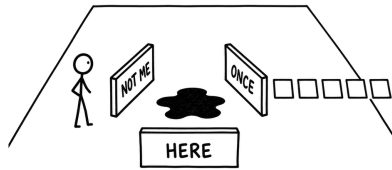
## Rehearse the breakthrough in the room where it will happen

Pick the outcome that gives you goosebumps. Find the actual room — visit it, or find photographs of it. List the handful of moments that will decide it. Then sit somewhere comfortable, settle, and run those moments in order, from inside your own body, in full sensory detail, with the emotion turned up. Finish by letting yourself enjoy the win.

- The target is a sense of having been there before. Sylvie Bernier knew the time of her 1984 Olympic final, where the scoreboard would be, where the coaches would sit; when she reached the podium it was like I had been there before. Around twenty minutes is as long as most people can hold the control, detail and feeling required, so a short performance can be run whole and a long one has to be run as key moments. Then rehearse the disruptions separately. Name three things that could throw you, spend ten seconds on the problem and at least thirty on getting back in control — the ratio is the point. Do enough of them and even an unrehearsed surprise finds the subroutine already built.

This works because your nervous system takes it seriously, which means a rehearsed failure is also taken seriously. Keep the content controlled. If an image of a mistake appears, stop the scene, reset it, and run it through to the ending you want.

### THREE WALLS ROUND ONE SPILL



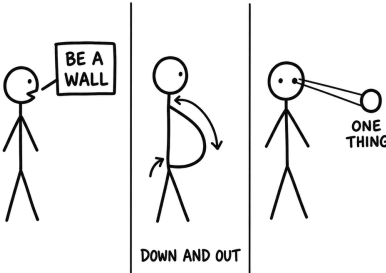
## Explain the setback as temporary, limited, and not you

The moment something goes wrong, say three things to yourself, in this order. It happened that one time. It happened in that one place. That is not how I really am. Each sentence blocks one of the three routes by which a single bad moment turns into a general belief about yourself.

- The three traps are distinct and they escalate. Temporary blocks here I go again. Limited blocks now the whole day is going down the drain — the golfer who puts one drive in the trees keeps it from spreading to his irons and his putting. Non-representative blocks the last and worst one, maybe I'm not good enough. Martin Seligman gave his Attributional Styles Questionnaire to the entire incoming West Point class of 1988; the cadets who quit during basic training or the following year had significantly more pessimistic explanatory styles than those who stayed. Maddie Burns, a college lacrosse goalkeeper, concedes seven goals in an average game and treats each one as just that one time, seven times a game.

This is not denial and it does not dissolve responsibility. You still acknowledge what happened, you still take the consequences, and you still go and fix the thing. What you refuse is the generalisation — the move from a fact about one moment to a verdict on your whole capability.

## CUE, BREATHE, ATTACH



## Cue, breathe, attach — before every single engagement

Before each rep, pitch, shift, patient, call or meeting, run three steps in about ten seconds. Cue your conviction with a short powerful phrase. Breathe your body — belly out on the inhale, abs in on the exhale, two or three times, finishing on a strong settling breath out. Attach your attention to the single thing that matters right now, and let yourself become genuinely curious about it.

- The cue is a statement, not a question, and it names a process rather than an outcome. Be a wall. Time to cruise. Do it like you know it. Here's my chance. Michael Phelps's coach Bob Bowman described watching an Olympic coach tell an already-nervous skater this is what you've worked so hard for; she was so tight the two of them missed a high five, and she skated badly. The rival's coach made small talk and one technical point. Process talk lowers arousal; outcome talk raises it. An offensive lineman runs this sixty times in a game. A neurosurgeon runs it between the steps of an operation. Danny Brière ran it in ninety seconds on the bench between shifts.

Breathing is the one autonomic function with a manual override, so do it properly. A correct inhale is down and out — the diaphragm drops, the belly expands on all sides, the lower ribs lift. It is not the upward shoulder lift most people were taught. The exhale is up and in, abdominals and obliques drawing toward the spine.

## VOCABULARY

Most of these are ordinary words used with unusual precision, and the precision is the point. A performer who has a name for the thing that just happened in their head can do something about it.

### **The first victory**

Sun Tzu's phrase, and the book's organising idea: the victory won in your own mind before you enter the arena. Victorious warriors win first and then go to war; defeated warriors go to war first and then seek to win.

### **Confidence**

A sense of certainty about your ability that allows you to bypass conscious thought and execute unconsciously. Note what is absent from this definition: any requirement that the certainty be justified.

### **The mental bank account**

The running total of every thought you have entertained about yourself and your field. It rises on memories of effort, success and progress, and falls on replayed setbacks and rehearsed future trouble.

### **The daily ESP**

A five-minute end-of-day journal entry with three headings: effort, success, progress. One instance of each, however small. Three deposits minimum, every day, regardless of what the day looked like.

### **Immediate progress review**

The same filtering done between activities rather than at the end of the day. Take the best rep of the drill you just finished into the drill you are walking to. A dozen small deposits per session instead of one.

### **Affirmation**

A statement of the reality you want, made in the present tense as though it is already true. To affirm is to say yes. Five specifications: first person, present tense, positive, precise, powerful.

### **Envisioning**

The deliberate production of an emotionally powerful, multi-sensory imagined experience of a desired event — sight, sound, touch, smell, position and movement, not pictures alone. Distinguished from daydreaming by control, detail and genuine feeling.

### **Explanatory style**

Martin Seligman's term for how you explain the causes of what happens to you. Pessimists read bad events as permanent, pervasive and personal. The corrective is to read them as temporary, limited and non-representative.

### **The shooter's mentality**

Two beliefs held at once, neither of them logical: a miss means the next one is more likely to go in, and a hit means the next one is too. Not defensible as probability. Extremely effective as a state of mind.

## QUICK REFERENCE

|                               |                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| THE DEFINITION                | Certainty about your ability sufficient to bypass conscious thought and execute unconsciously. Confidence is the absence of interference, not an addition.                                            |
| THE ACCOUNT                   | A running total of thoughts, not a record of events. Deposits: effort, success, progress, and the future you want. Withdrawals: replayed setbacks and rehearsed trouble.                              |
| FOUR FOUNDATIONS              | Thoughts drive physical state. You will never be perfect. Your nerves will fire before anything that matters. Practice pays late and unevenly.                                                        |
| THREE SOURCES                 | Past — Top 10, daily ESP, immediate progress review. Present — affirmations on a trigger. Future — envisioning, and the flat tire drill.                                                              |
| FIVE SPECS FOR AN AFFIRMATION | First person. Present tense. Positive. Precise. Powerful. State what you want more of, never what you are trying to avoid.                                                                            |
| FOUR SPECS FOR ENVISIONING    | Control the content. Maximum sensory detail. Internal perspective. Real emotion. Twenty minutes is the ceiling.                                                                                       |
| THREE SAFEGUARDS              | Temporary, limited, non-representative. Acknowledge, silence, replace. Then the shooter's mentality: a miss means the next one is due.                                                                |
| IN THE ARENA                  | Take stock of the account, the task, the hidden opponent and the room. Decide you are enough, then statements only. Every engagement: cue the conviction, breathe down and out, attach the attention. |
| AFTERWARDS                    | What happened, so what does it tell you, now what will you do. Eighty percent of the review on the gems after a loss, sixty after a win.                                                              |

*Victorious warriors win first and then go to war. Defeated warriors go to war first and then seek to win.*